

The Typical Imaging Process

Organisations typically buy uniform hardware in bulk. Thus your entire workplace is more likely to be supplied by the same OEM or even an assembler—making sure that the hardware components of each machine are the same across the office. This ensures that future hardware upgrades are uniform across the organisation. It also greatly reduces maintenance, both hardware and software, since the support staff need only troubleshoot one uniform hardware set across the workplace.

Under such a scenario, when you need to deploy an operating system across numerous machines, or perhaps just an upgrade across your systems, you need to use imaging technology to do the deployment. The idea is to ensure that the same set of software is running across all your uniform hardware. A typical imaging process runs something like this:

1. The administrator installs Windows on one system, called the host system, and then configures that system as he would ideally like all systems to be configured. For example, he might install printer drivers and create two partitions, one for data and another for the OS itself. This involves adding and removing components, installing commonly used apps, and tweaking the UI and other settings.
2. The administrator then runs deployment tools that clean up the install on the host system. This cleanup is required to remove any references to the particular computer and to make the install more generic in nature.
3. This host system is then shut down and the admin boots into the Windows PE environment.
4. An imaging tool is now run to create a single image of the host system. This image will then be deployed across all available systems.
5. The image of the host can be updated with applications, security fixes, service packs, language packs and so on, as needed.
6. The image is finally replicated to one or more computers.

1.4.6. Settings are XML-controlled

Configuration information that was earlier stored in various text files find a new home under Vista: Unattend.txt, sysprep.inf, cmdlines.txt, and winbom.ini are now all replaced by a single XML file called unattend.xml.

You can still edit the file in question using a text editor of your choice, the Windows System Image Manager tool mentioned above can be used to inspect the Vista image to determine which settings are available for deployment, allowing you to configure each one.